

Chapter 22

Ethical Challenges and AI Governance in Social Work



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1 Introduction to Ethical Principles in AI and Social Work

Artificial intelligence (AI) is increasingly woven into the social work profession, from predictive risk models in child welfare practice and research (Gillingham, 2020) to AI-powered mental health chatbots in practice (Yang et al., 2025) to simulation teaching tools in education (Heinsch et al., 2024). Empirical and conceptual work now describes how AI is being used to conduct risk assessments (Rosholm et al., 2024), triage cases (Cuccaro-Alamin et al., 2017), detect patterns in administrative data (Rosholm et al., 2024), and support remote or automated service delivery (Yang et al., 2025). At the same time, these applications raise specific ethical concerns within the field of social work, including algorithmic bias and discrimination, lack of transparency and explainability, threats to privacy and confidentiality, and the potential erosion of professional judgment and client trust (Saeidnia et al., 2024; Weiner et al., 2024). Professional bodies such as the National Association of Social Workers (NASW) have updated technology standards, reaffirmed digital-age ethical obligations, and begun issuing guidance on AI (NASW et al., 2017), signaling that AI is no longer a speculative issue but a practical governance priority for social work (Reamer, 2013, 2023).

In parallel, a dense landscape of AI ethics and governance frameworks has emerged across sectors. Comparative reviews of national strategies, corporate

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519

guidelines, and civil-society frameworks identify a strong convergence on a small set of recurring principles for “trustworthy AI”: fairness and non-discrimination, transparency and explainability, human rights and human-centeredness, accountability, and safety (Corrêa et al., 2023; Fjeld et al., 2020; Jobin et al., 2019; Lee et al., *in press*). Building on these converging principles, international and regional instruments such as the Organisation for Economic Co-operation and Development (OECD) Recommendation on Artificial Intelligence (OECD, 2025), United Nations Educational, Scientific and Cultural Organization (UNESCO) Recommendation on the Ethics of Artificial Intelligence (UNESCO, 2024), the European Union’s General Data Protection Regulation (GDPR) and Artificial Intelligence Act (European Parliament, 2025), and the U.S. National Institute of Standards and Technology (NIST) AI Risk Management Framework (AI RMF; NIST, 2023) codify expectations that AI systems should respect human rights, support inclusive and sustainable development, and be subject to risk-based governance and meaningful human oversight.

Importantly, AI ethics principles reflected in these frameworks closely mirror, rather than replace, the ethical foundations of social work. Social work’s ethical codes and standards, such as the NASW Code of Ethics (NASW, *n.d.*) and the International Federation of Social Workers (IFSW) Global Social Work Statement of Ethical Principles (IFSW, 2018), affirm core commitments to human dignity and worth, human rights, social justice, the importance of human relationships, integrity, competence, and the ethical use of technology in practice (Reamer, 2013; NASW et al., 2017). Fairness and non-discrimination in AI resonate with social work’s opposition to structural injustice, equity, and transparency. Moreover, the human-centeredness of AI aligns with person-in-environment perspectives, self-determination, informed consent, and voluntary client participation. Accountability and safety of AI reflect social workers’ duties to prevent harm, do good, and answer for decisions that affect people’s lives. These have been reflected in recent AI ethical frameworks developed by social workers to inform the responsible use of AI in social work research, teaching, and practice (Ahn et al., 2025; Lee et al., *in press*; Ricciardelli et al., 2025). For example, social work scholars in collaboration with leaders of the Society for Social Work and Research (SSWR), which is the premier research organization of the social work profession, have developed the Equity, Transparency, Human-Centeredness, Integrity, Collaboration, and Safety (ETHICS) framework, outlining six key ethical principles to uphold in social work research and providing recommendations for their practical applications (Lee et al., *in press*).

Yet even with this broad alignment of AI principles and social work ethics, applying these ideals in social work presents significant challenges. Bridging the gap between high-level “trustworthy AI” guidelines and real-world social work practice requires grappling with the profession’s unique context and responsibilities. Social workers often serve vulnerable populations in situations where trust, empathy, and human relationships are paramount (Garrett, 2025; Patton et al., 2023). Consequently, any AI system introduced into social work practice must be

held to higher ethical standards to avoid eroding these foundations. For example, scholars caution that algorithmic tools can conflict with core social work values, raising concerns about client confidentiality, informed consent, self-determination, and treating clients as whole persons (Gabriels et al., 2025; Reamer, 2023). This means social workers have a proactive ethical obligation not only to vet and adapt AI tools carefully, but also to advocate for their appropriate and ethical use (Flaherty & Krishnan, 2025). In fact, if left unchecked, AI could perpetuate biases or reduce the human element of care, undermining social work's commitment to equity, justice, and authentic human connection. Therefore, social workers must take the lead in ensuring AI integration uplifts rather than undermines professional ethics.

This chapter responds to that challenge by linking AI ethics principles with concrete governance arrangements tailored to social work. Section 2 reviews major global and regional AI governance frameworks, including the OECD Principles on AI, UNESCO's Recommendation on the Ethics of AI, the General Data Protection Regulation (GDPR), the EU AI Act, America's AI Action Plan, and the NIST AI Risk Management Framework (European Union, 2024; NIST, 2023; OECD, 2019; UNESCO, 2021; White House, 2025), and considers how they embed fairness, transparency, human-centeredness, accountability, and safety in their frameworks. Section 3 develops an institutional and risk-based AI governance model for social work, distinguishing unacceptable, high, limited, and minimal-risk applications and the corresponding requirements for ethical review and human oversight. Sections 4, 5, 6 examine cross-cutting issues of data governance, privacy protection, transparency, accountability, fairness, inclusion, and participatory governance. Section 7 focuses on the social worker's role in AI governance, while Sect. 8 identifies key challenges, gaps, and directions for future policy, practice, and research. Together, these sections move from principles to practice, offering a framework for ensuring that AI is governed in ways that strengthen, rather than erode, the ethical foundations of social work.

2 Global and Regional AI Governance Frameworks

Over the past five years, AI governance, which refers to the processes, standards, and guardrails to ensure AI systems and tools are ethical and safe (IBM, n.d.), has emerged as a central global priority (Davtyan, 2024; Zhu, 2024). At the international level, the OECD Principles on AI (2019) established the first intergovernmental standard for responsible and human-centered AI. In 2021, UNESCO's Recommendation (United Nations Educational, Scientific and Cultural Organization [UNESCO], 2021) on the Ethics of AI expanded this foundation by emphasizing human rights, transparency, fairness, and oversight.

In Europe, the European Union has led regulatory efforts. *The General Data Protection Regulation* (European Union, 2016) set global benchmarks for data

protection (Corning, 2024). Building on this, the *EU Artificial Intelligence Act*, a comprehensive AI act that applies to all 27 EU member states (European Union, 2024), introduced a risk-based approach, with phased implementation from 2025 to 2027, to regulate high-risk and general-purpose AI systems (Lewis et al., 2025).

In the United States, AI governance primarily relies on executive directives and voluntary standards rather than binding legislation. The America's *AI Action Plan* (The White House, 2025) establishes a national policy roadmap that coordinates federal agencies to foster safe, innovative, and globally competitive AI development. On the other hand, the *NIST AI Risk Management Framework* (National Institute of Standards and Technology [NIST], 2023) provides organizations with a practical, risk-based framework for assessing, mitigating, and monitoring AI risks throughout the system lifecycle. At the same time, it is essential to note that, unlike Europe, there is no one overarching federal AI law in the United States, which has led to individual states creating their own regulations and thus resulting in a patchwork of complex and varied AI legislation across the country (Crenshaw & Richards, 2025).

Overall, these frameworks indicate the reflexive evolution of AI governance, establishing a conceptual foundation for regulatory practices across diverse contexts. The following sub-sections outline how major global and regional frameworks translate ethical principles into institutionalized governance mechanisms and concrete policy measures.

2.1 *OECD AI Principles and Recommendations for Policymakers*

The *Principles on Artificial Intelligence* (2019), adopted by the Organisation for Economic Co-operation and Development (OECD) and endorsed by more than 40 countries, represent the first intergovernmental standard for trustworthy AI. The OECD principles outline five core principles and five corresponding policy recommendations for member states, emphasizing inclusive growth, human-centered values and fairness, transparency, safety, and accountability of AI actors (OECD, 2019).

Table 22.1 shows how the principles of AI are translated into practical policy recommendations that operationalize ethical goals (OECD, 2019). For example, to realize the principles of transparency and explainability, governments are encouraged to establish regulatory sandboxes—controlled environments that allow developers and regulators to test AI systems and decision-making processes, and to refine transparency requirements before real-world deployment (OECD, 2023). Similarly, to ensure human-centered values and fairness, policymakers are advised to create data trusts and shared infrastructures that protect privacy and ensure equitable access to AI resources. The recommendations also call for investment in AI research for social good, capacity building for safety and risk management, and international coordination to harmonize accountability standards (Del Ser et al., 2023).

Table 22.1 OECD AI principles and recommendations for policymakers

OECD AI Principle	Corresponding Recommendation for Policymakers
1. Inclusive growth, sustainable development, and well-being	Invest in AI research and development that advances social good and sustainable outcomes; ensure public and private R&D addresses societal challenges, environmental sustainability, and inclusive economic opportunities
2. Human-centered values and fairness (respect for human rights, diversity, fairness, privacy, and autonomy)	Foster an inclusive AI-enabling ecosystem that protects individual rights and embeds fairness, accessibility, and equity across sectors; promote shared infrastructures (e.g., data trusts) that safeguard privacy and non-discrimination
3. Transparency and explainability	Shape an enabling and interoperable policy and governance environment that mandates transparency, documentation, and accountability; use agile regulation and regulatory sandboxes to ensure explainable and traceable AI deployment
4. Robustness, security, and safety	Build human capacity and prepare for labor-market transformation by enhancing technical competence, safety culture, and risk-management skills; strengthen institutional capability to monitor, test, and certify AI reliability
5. Accountability of AI actors	Encourage international cooperation for trustworthy AI, promoting global alignment on accountability standards, interoperability, and shared auditing practices; support multilateral frameworks for oversight and redress mechanisms

Note. Adapted from OECD Principles on Artificial Intelligence, Organisation for Economic Co-operation and Development (OECD, 2019), <https://www.oecd.org/en/topics/sub-issues/ai-principles.html>

2.2 UNESCO Policy and Governance Recommendations on AI

The United Nations Educational, Scientific and Cultural Organization (UNESCO) *Recommendation on the Ethics of Artificial Intelligence* (2021) advances a broader human rights and social justice perspective. Adopted by 193 member states, it represents the first global normative instrument dedicated to AI governance. Compared to the OECD’s development and innovation framework, UNESCO’s recommendation centers on protecting human dignity, equality, diversity, and environmental sustainability (Samarawickrama, 2022).

It calls on states to establish national AI ethics councils, implement ethical impact assessments (EIAs), and integrate AI ethics education into curricula and professional training. The document also promotes data responsibility, green AI development, and international, multi-stakeholder cooperation (UNESCO, 2021). To ensure accountability, UNESCO urges continuous monitoring, evaluation, and implementation through national ethics commissions, reporting mechanisms, and multilateral collaboration. Collectively, these measures establish a comprehensive, human-centered governance architecture that links ethics with actionable regulatory practice (Allahrakha, 2024; UNESCO, 2021).

Table 22.2 Seven principles of lawful data processing

Principle	Description
1. Lawfulness, Fairness, and Transparency	Data must be processed lawfully, fairly, and transparently to individuals.
2. Purpose Limitation	Data must be collected for specified, explicit, and legitimate purposes.
3. Data Minimization	Only data necessary for the intended purpose should be processed.
4. Accuracy	Data must be accurate and kept up to date.
5. Storage Limitation	Data must not be stored longer than necessary.
6. Integrity and Confidentiality	Data must be processed securely to prevent unauthorized access or loss.
7. Accountability	Controllers are responsible for demonstrating compliance with all principles.

Note. Adapted from Regulation (EU) 2016/679 of the European Parliament and of the Council of 27 April 2016 on the protection of natural persons with regard to the processing of personal data and on the free movement of such data (General Data Protection Regulation), European Union (2016), Official Journal of the European Union. <https://eur-lex.europa.eu/eli/reg/2016/679/oj>

2.3 General Data Protection Regulation (GDPR)

The General Data Protection Regulation (GDPR), adopted by Europe Union (EU) in 2016 and enforced since May 25, 2018 (European Union, 2016), is the world’s most comprehensive data protection law, establishes legal standards for how personal data are collected, processed, stored, and transferred, emphasizing individual control, transparency, and accountability (Amoo et al., 2024; Sealey, 2020).

The regulation is central to AI governance because most AI systems rely on large volumes of personal or sensitive data (e.g., health, demographic, and behavioral data). By defining seven foundational principles of lawful data processing (Table 22.2), the regulation provides a normative blueprint for safeguarding individual rights and promoting the responsible and ethical development of AI (Cormack, 2021; European Union, 2016).

2.4 EU Artificial Intelligence Act

The European Union Artificial Intelligence Act (2024) is the world’s first comprehensive, legally binding framework for AI governance (Smuha, 2025). Unlike voluntary frameworks (e.g., OECD/UNESCO principles), it imposes legal obligations on providers and deployers of AI systems placed on or used in the EU, with prohibitions, risk-tiered duties (especially for high-risk AI), general-purpose AI (GPAI) rules (including a systemic-risk tier), conformity assessment and market surveillance, and significant fines (Butt, 2024; Gstrein et al., 2024).

Table 22.3 Risk-based regulatory framework of the EU AI Act

Risk level	Regulatory intensity	Examples
Unacceptable Risk	Completely prohibited	Social scoring systems, manipulative AI that distorts human behavior, or indiscriminate scraping of facial images to create recognition databases.
High Risk	Strict regulation (mandatory compliance obligations)	AI used for medical diagnosis, recruitment and hiring, judicial decision-making, social welfare allocation, or public security surveillance.
Limited Risk	Transparency obligations	Chatbots, emotion-recognition systems, and AI-generated content (users must be clearly informed).
Minimal or No Risk	Largely unregulated	Game AI, recommendation engines, or spam filters.

Note. Adapted from Regulation (EU) 2024/1689 of the European Parliament and of the Council of 13 June 2024 laying down harmonized rules on artificial intelligence (Artificial Intelligence Act), European Union (2024), Official Journal of the European Union. <https://eur-lex.europa.eu/eli/reg/2024/1689/oj>

The *EU AI Act* introduces a risk-based regulatory framework based on differentiated levels of governance. As Table 22.3 shows, all AI systems are categorized into four risk levels, each with a corresponding level of legal oversight intensity (European Union, 2024).

This risk-based governance framework allows proportional regulation. The higher the potential risks to fundamental rights and safety, the stricter the oversight, transparency, and accountability mechanisms required (European Union, 2024).

Under the *EU AI Act*, high-risk AI systems, including those in health, employment, and social welfare services, are subject to the strictest regulatory obligations. Developers and deployers must establish risk management frameworks to ensure system safety, data quality, and fairness (European Union, 2024). They are required to maintain technical documentation, guarantee transparency and human oversight, and demonstrate robustness and reliability under diverse contexts (Nolte et al., 2025). Before deployment, high-risk systems must undergo conformity assessment and obtain Conformité Européenne (CE) certification. Continuous monitoring and incident reporting ensure accountability throughout the system’s lifecycle (Gornet & Maxwell, 2024). Collectively, these measures aim to make high-risk AI systems safe, traceable, and human-centered within the EU governance framework.

In addition, the *EU AI Act* introduces foundational governance requirements for general-purpose AI (GPAI) systems (European Union, 2024), focusing on transparency, accountability, and traceability across the AI workflow. For GPAI, providers must maintain detailed technical documentation on model design, training, and limitations; ensure compliance with copyright and data-transparency requirements by publishing summaries of training data; and share essential information with downstream users to enable safe deployment. They are also required to monitor performance, address risks, and cooperate with regulators. Until harmonized standards are finalized, GPAI providers should adhere to the approved GPAI Code of

Practice, which promotes adherence to the EU AI Act's legal obligations on safety, transparency, and copyright of GPAI models and serves as evidence of compliance (European Union, 2024, 2025; Nolte et al., 2025).

2.5 *America's AI Action Plan (2025)*

Released by the White House in July 2025, *America's AI Action Plan (2025)* serves as the United States' first comprehensive national strategy for AI. It outlines a long-term policy framework that integrates innovation, safety, and competitiveness, aiming to strengthen domestic AI capabilities while shaping global governance norms.

In terms of AI governance, *America's AI Action Plan (2025)* presents a non-regulatory, innovation-driven vision, centered on voluntary standards and multi-agency coordination. Governance is framed as a mechanism to promote transparency, safety, and accountability without hindering innovation. The plan designates the White House Office of Science and Technology Policy, the National Institute of Standards and Technology, and the United States Department of Commerce as core governance bodies responsible for developing risk-management protocols, transparency standards, and model evaluation procedures. It institutionalizes four key pillars: (1) risk and safety governance, (2) transparency and accountability, (3) ethical oversight, and (4) public-private collaboration—supported by reporting requirements and incident-monitoring systems (The White House, 2025).

In contrast to the European Union's regulatory framework, which enforces binding, risk-based legal obligations through *the AI Act* (European Union, 2024), the U.S. approach prioritizes flexibility, innovation, and market self-regulation. Rather than prescribing uniform compliance requirements, it relies on industry-led codes of practice, voluntary risk frameworks (e.g., NIST AI RMF), and cross-sectoral cooperation to operationalize accountability (The White House, 2025).

2.6 *NIST AI Risk Management Framework*

The AI Risk Management Framework (AI RMF) is a voluntary guidance document developed by the U.S. National Institute of Standards and Technology (NIST) and officially released in January 2023 (NIST, 2023). The U.S. National AI Initiative Act of 2020 mandated that organizations identify, assess, manage, and mitigate risks associated with AI systems throughout their lifecycle (NIST, 2023). As a non-prescriptive, flexible, and consensus-based standard for both public and private sectors, the *AI RMF* emphasizes that AI risk management is governance of uncertainty and harm, not mere compliance. It situates risk in a socio-technical context, acknowledging that AI systems' impacts depend not only on code and data, but also

Table 22.4 Four core functions of AI RMF

Function	Purpose
Govern	Establish a culture of AI risk management and governance.
Map	Identify and contextualize AI risks.
Measure	Assess and evaluate risks quantitatively and qualitatively.
Manage	Treat, monitor, and adapt to AI risks over time.

Note. Adapted from Artificial Intelligence Risk Management Framework (AI RMF 1.0) (NIST AI 100–1), by National Institute of Standards and Technology (2023), U.S. Department of Commerce. <https://doi.org/10.6028/NIST.AI.100-1>

on how humans design, deploy, and interact with them (Dotan et al., 2024; NIST, 2023; Polemi et al., 2024).

NIST structures the *AI RMF*’s operational section around four interrelated core functions that apply across AI system design, development, deployment, and monitoring.

Table 22.4 (NIST, 2023) outlines the four core functions of the NIST *AI RMF*: Govern, Map, Measure, and Manage. These functions construct a continuous process for the development of trustworthy and responsible AI. Govern establishes accountability and ethical oversight; Map identifies potential risks and affected stakeholders; Measure evaluates accuracy, bias, and robustness through systematic assessment; and Manage mitigates and monitors risks throughout the AI lifecycle (NIST, 2023). Collectively, these functions integrate transparency, adaptability, and responsibility into AI governance practices.

3 Institutional and Risk-Based AI Governance in Social Work

AI governance in social work should be institutionalized rather than aspirational. As AI becomes increasingly integrated into social work, it is reshaping key professional processes, including early risk detection, intervention design, decision-making, service delivery, and evaluation (Sigfrids et al., 2022; Wang, 2025). These AI-augmented practices introduce new forms of uncertainty and ethical complexity, highlighting the urgent need for context-specific frameworks and regulatory mechanisms (Lee et al., in press; Reamer, 2022; Ricciardelli et al., 2025). Institutionalized governance can ensure that AI applications in social work remain grounded in ethical values, such as respect for human rights, individual well-being, and social justice, thereby improving social equity and well-being (Wang, 2025; Murko et al., 2024).

To institutionalize AI governance, establishing formal oversight structures, such as AI ethics committees and clear lines of accountability, together with a risk-based governance framework, is essential. Social work operates in ethically sensitive environments where decisions shape individuals’ rights, well-being, and life opportunities (Juujärvi et al., 2020). Compared to commercial domains, AI in social work must respond to complex human contexts, where algorithmic bias can cause disproportionate harm to vulnerable populations (Lee et al., *in press*; Patton et al., 2023; Reamer, 2023). The strength of a risk-based governance approach lies in its capacity to deliver context-specific oversight that distinguishes among varying levels of harm, vulnerability, and professional responsibility. Such a framework enables agencies to adopt proportionate, context-appropriate governance measures, providing a balanced mechanism that protects clients while supporting responsible and ethical innovation.

Inspired by the *EU AI Act* (European Union, 2024), Table 22.5 drafts a social work-specific risk taxonomy that aligns regulatory intensity with ethical risk and potential social impact.

Table 22.5 Proposed social work-specific risk-based AI governance framework

Risk Level	Regulatory	Applications	Governance Requirements
Unacceptable Risk	Prohibited	Profile clients based on race, gender, disability, or socioeconomic status. Manipulative recommendation tools that distort caseworker judgment. Cause unsustainable environmental impact	Must not be developed or deployed; subject to institutional and legal prohibition
High Risk	Strict Regulation (mandatory ethical review and continuous oversight)	Predictive analytics for child welfare, health risk, eligibility assessment for social benefits, chatbots used in therapy or other types of therapeutic treatments, or automated intake triage	Mandatory EIA, algorithmic transparency, data quality validation, fairness audit, and human-in-the-loop decision control
Limited Risk	Moderate Regulation (transparency and accountability obligations)	Chatbots for client communication (e.g., case management, information), emotion analysis tools, or resource recommendation systems	Documentation of model purpose and limitations, explainability assurance, and periodic bias testing
Minimal Risk	Light Governance (self-regulation and monitoring)	Scheduling systems, administrative automation, or workflow optimization tools	Basic ethical compliance declaration, data protection adherence, and internal monitoring for misuse or drift

Note. This framework is an original conceptual synthesis created by the author. While informed by the risk-based approach articulated in the *EU AI Act* (European Union, 2024), the structure, categories, and governance requirements are newly formulated for social work practice

3.1 Unacceptable Risk: Ethical Red Lines and Prohibition

AI systems that fundamentally violate equity or human rights, or pose unacceptable risks, must be strictly prohibited, such as those that profile clients based on race, gender, disability, or socioeconomic status (European Union, 2024). These AI systems are identified as inherently undermining social justice or human dignity, breaching the moral foundation of social work. Institutional policies should explicitly codify ethical “red lines,” including prohibitions on AI models with unmitigated bias, discriminatory data, or unsustainable environmental impact (Roy et al., 2025). Social work agencies should adopt a “diagnose–mitigate–document” procedure for dataset evaluation (Ortega-Bolaños et al., 2024). If bias or harm cannot be adequately corrected, the system should not be deployed.

3.2 High Risk: Mandatory Ethical Review and Human Oversight

High-risk AI systems, such as predictive analytics for child welfare/protection, mental health triage, chatbots employed in therapeutic processes, or welfare eligibility assessments, directly influence life-altering decisions. As the *EU AI Act* illustrates, the governance of high-risk AI systems must follow the principles of safety, transparency, and human-centeredness (European Union, 2024). Agencies are required to conduct EIAs, submit systems to independent review boards, and maintain human-in-the-loop oversight throughout design to deployment. Multi-stakeholder involvement, including practitioners, ethicists, and affected communities, should guide oversight, insisting on continuous monitoring and corrective accountability rather than one-time compliance.

3.3 Limited Risk: Transparency and Accountability Obligations

Limited-risk systems, such as chatbots for lower risk communications (e.g., information sharing, case management tasks), emotional recognition tools, or recommendation systems, may not directly determine outcomes but can still affect communication, trust, and perceived fairness. In line with the transparency and integrity principles of the social work ethical framework (Reamer, 2022), these systems require clear disclosure of AI involvement and limitations. Social workers and clients should be informed when interacting with AI tools, ensuring informed consent and user comprehension. In parallel, periodic fairness and accuracy audits must be conducted, and all deployments should maintain accessible documentation for accountability.

3.4 *Minimal Risk: Ethical Self-Regulation and Professional Learning*

Minimal-risk systems, such as workflow automation or scheduling tools, pose limited direct ethical risks but still require ongoing professional responsibility (European Union, 2024). Risk-based governance requires an emphasis on ethical self-monitoring, compliance documentation, and an internal audit process. Agencies should foster a culture of accountability through AI literacy and training programs (e.g., provision of continuing education credits to maintain social work licensure), enabling social workers to identify potential ethical risks. Even without external regulation, embedding ethical reflection into daily service delivery ensures that low-risk tools continue to uphold social work's core values of trust, transparency, and public service.

This proposed tiered AI risk-governance framework helps translate the six ethical principles—Equity, Transparency, Human-centeredness, Integrity, Collaboration, and Safety (ETHICS) outlined by Lee et al. (in press)—into actionable safeguards tailored for the social work context. As the authors of the ETHICS framework in social work research suggest, ethical AI governance must be proactive, context-sensitive, and value-driven, ensuring that systems that promote efficiency do not erode the core ethics of social work (Lee et al., in press). By calibrating oversight intensity to risk exposure, this AI risk-governance framework preserves innovation while responding to potential ethical risks.

4 Data Governance, Privacy, and Transparency

Building on the institutional principles and AI risk-based regulatory framework, effective AI governance in social work also depends on robust data management, which serves as a foundation for ensuring individual privacy and transparency in AI applications.

4.1 *Data Governance*

Building on the principles of the GDPR, the UNESCO *Recommendation on the Ethics of Artificial Intelligence* (UNESCO, 2021), and the OECD *AI Principles* (OECD, 2019), data governance must be anchored in quality, representativeness, and purpose limitation. Social work AI systems should collect only the data strictly necessary for defined service purposes and ensure that each data use remains consistent with its original ethical intent. In parallel, datasets must be continually audited for accuracy and bias, especially regarding marginalized or underrepresented groups (Knowles et al., 2023).

A robust data-governance framework requires clearly defined responsibilities, including the designation of data stewards or data-protection officers to oversee data flows, metadata documentation, and ethical compliance (Verhulst, 2025). Institutions and agencies should maintain transparent records of data lineage and establish review protocols for data retention and deletion. Following the *NIST AI RMF* (2023), social work agencies should regularly “map” their data sources and document limitations in representation or collection context. Periodic data-quality assessments and human audits can ensure that training data and client information remain trustworthy, minimizing systematic bias in the AI applications.

4.2 Privacy Protection

Given that social work AI applications routinely handle highly sensitive, context-specific information related to health, disability, family safety, and social benefits, individuals’ privacy protection must be treated as a core governance pillar. The GDPR and the *EU AI Act* (2024) both require data controllers to demonstrate lawful processing, consent management, and accountability mechanisms for all AI-driven decisions. Social work agencies and organizations should conduct a Data Protection Impact Assessment (DPIA) or EIA before introducing any AI application that could affect clients’ rights or access to services (Chang, 2021).

In practice, conducting a DPIA or EIA involves a structured process that begins at the earliest stages of AI design and continues throughout the system’s lifecycle. Organizations should first identify the potential ethical, social, and human rights risks posed by the AI application, with particular attention to how it might affect vulnerable or marginalized clients. Based on the findings, social work agencies are expected to document the purposes of data use, risk mitigation strategies, and the justification for decisions in a transparent and auditable manner (Chang, 2021). Continuous monitoring and periodic re-evaluation are essential to maintain ethical alignment as systems evolve, ensuring that AI tools consistently uphold human dignity, fairness, and social justice—the moral foundation of social work practice.

4.3 Transparency and Accountability

Transparency is another foundation of ethical and trustworthy AI (Knowles et al., 2023). According to the OECD AI Principles (OECD, 2019), transparency requires openness about how AI systems operate, what data they apply, and how decisions are generated. The *EU AI Act* (European Union, 2024) further requires providers of general-purpose and high-risk AI systems to disclose documentation regarding their training data, model capabilities, and limitations.

In the social work field, transparency means that both social workers and clients can clearly acknowledge the scope, purpose, and limitations of AI used in service

delivery (Devlieghere & Gillingham, 2020). When AI applications are used for assessments, eligibility decisions, or intervention planning in social work practice, explanations must be accessible and culturally sensitive to non-technical audiences. Agencies should document when and how AI systems are involved, disclose the frameworks that guide their outputs, and clarify the mechanisms for human oversight. By embedding the principle of transparency from data collection to results explanation, social workers enhance public trust, informed consent, and professional accountability, ensuring that AI remains ethical and context-aware.

5 Accountability and Oversight

Accountability and oversight are essential to ensuring that AI applications in social work stay ethical and publicly trustworthy. Accountability defines who is responsible for potential ethical outcomes and how oversight of AI is exercised from design to deployment. Building on global frameworks such as the OECD AI Principles, UNESCO's *Recommendation on the Ethics of Artificial Intelligence* (UNESCO, 2021), and the *EU AI Act* (European Union, 2024), accountability in social work requires both institutional structures and professional practices that enable monitoring and correction. This section outlines three complementary dimensions—institutional accountability, professional oversight, and continuous evaluation—that together form a sustainable AI governance architecture to promote accountability.

5.1 Institutional Accountability

Institutionalized structure provides the backbone of accountability and AI governance in social work. According to the OECD AI Principle on Accountability (OECD, 2019) and the UNESCO *Recommendation on the Ethics of AI* (UNESCO, 2021), institutions that design or deploy AI should be able to demonstrate compliance with ethical, legal, and professional standards. This requires clearly defined responsibilities and a reporting mechanism that specifies who is accountable for each stage of the AI lifecycle—from data collection and model training to deployment and monitoring.

Social work agencies should establish AI ethics and oversight committees to review documentation, approve deployments, and coordinate post-deployment audits. These committees serve as independent governance bodies, ensuring that AI systems align with regulatory frameworks (European Union, 2024) and with the ethical principles of social work. Agencies are also required to develop incident-reporting protocols to enable the timely identification and remediation of algorithmic harm (e.g., discriminatory treatment based on race, gender, and other client

identities, biased risk assessments, misdiagnosis, breaches of confidentiality, and privacy). Such mechanisms can provide institutionalized accountability as an ongoing governance function rather than a one-time compliance.

5.2 Professional and Procedural Oversight

In real-world practices, accountability extends to social workers and interdisciplinary teams who apply AI tools in daily service delivery. While AI can enhance efficiency and support decision-making, it should not replace professional judgment or the ethical responsibility to contextualize interventions. The NIST AI Risk Management Framework (NIST, 2023) and UNESCO's governance guidance (UNESCO, 2021) emphasize the importance of human-in-the-loop mechanisms that allow users to monitor, override, or recalibrate AI outputs when necessary.

Thereby, social workers should be trained and equipped with AI literacy and ethical reasoning skills to identify biases and inappropriate generalizations in AI models. On the other hand, agencies can promote accountability through standardized documentation, such as recording when AI tools are used in case assessment or decision-making, and maintaining a clear audit trail of human approvals. Embedding these safeguards can transform oversight into a collaborative process, linking technical governance with social work ethical practice.

5.3 Continuous Evaluation and Ethical Learning

Accountability in AI governance does not end at deployment. It requires continuous evaluation, reflexivity, and institutional learning. For instance, the *EU AI Act* mandates post-market monitoring and incident reporting for high-risk systems (European Union, 2024), a regulation that social work agencies can adapt through ongoing ethical audits and periodic performance reviews. These evaluations should assess not only technical reliability but also social outcomes, such as whether AI applications improve accessibility, reduce discrimination, or inadvertently reinforce structural inequities.

Furthermore, social work agencies should maintain transparent channels for clients and social workers to report concerns or unexpected effects of AI applications, thereby reinforcing the accountability loop. Results from these evaluations should inform policy revisions and updates to technical models. This adaptive cycle aligns with the UNESCO framework's call for dynamic and participatory governance (Liu et al., 2024; UNESCO, 2021), which positions accountability not as punishment but as a process of collective reflection and continuous ethical improvement.

6 Fairness, Inclusion, and Participatory Governance

As the core ethics of social work, fairness, inclusion, and participation should be central pillars of AI governance as well (Lee et al., [in press](#); Reamer, 2023). Beyond technical optimization, social work practice requires AI systems that actively promote equity, non-discrimination, and social justice. In parallel, global frameworks such as UNESCO's Inclusion Agenda emphasize participatory and value-sensitive approaches that align AI development with human rights and cultural diversity (UNESCO, 2021). Fair and inclusive governance thus ensures that AI not only avoids harm but also contributes to the advancement of dignity and justice in social systems.

6.1 *Fairness and Non-Discrimination*

Fairness in AI governance refers to both procedural and distributive equity, ensuring that algorithmic processes do not systematically disadvantage any social group, especially historically marginalized and underserved groups (Leslie et al., 2024). According to the OECD AI Principles and the *EU AI Act* (European Union, 2024), fairness requires proactive assessment of bias in data, models, and outcomes. In social work, where professional decisions may affect clients' access to social welfare, mental health resources, or child protection services, even limited algorithmic biases can amplify existing inequities.

To practice fairness, agencies should develop and adopt quantitative fairness metrics, such as equalized odds, demographic parity, or disparate-impact ratios, to evaluate biases in model outputs (Leslie et al., 2024). These metrics must be complemented by qualitative, context-based evaluation that reflects the complex ecology of human need. In addition, periodic fairness audits and impact assessments should become integral to institutional review processes, ensuring that AI outputs align with ethical principles of non-discrimination and equity.

6.2 *Inclusion and Cultural Responsiveness*

Inclusion in AI governance extends beyond representation in data to demand active participation from diverse stakeholders throughout AI applications. The *UNESCO Recommendation on the Ethics of AI* (UNESCO, 2021) calls for participatory approaches that integrate community perspectives into AI system design, evaluation, and policy formation. For social work practices, inclusion means co-designing tools with social workers, clients, and community advocates who understand contextual and cultural nuances best (Tan et al., 2025).

Agencies should establish stakeholder advisory panels that include service users, marginalized groups, and local organizations. These panels can provide continuous feedback on system functionality, fairness, and accessibility. On the other hand, culturally responsive design of AI applications requires contextual and demographic adaptability, ensuring that AI tools respect the diversity of client contexts (Ozegalska-Lukasik & Lukasik, 2023). This participatory engagement transforms AI governance from a top-down regulatory framework into a co-creative process of social accountability.

6.3 Participatory and Reflexive Governance

Participatory governance refers to the process of embedding fairness and inclusion into institutional routines through deliberation, feedback, and collaborative decision-making (Tan et al., 2025). Agencies should incorporate participatory design methodologies, such as stakeholder workshops, value mapping, and ethical impact dialogues, at the early stages of AI system development. These mechanisms are promising for fostering reflexivity, enabling developers and social workers to question embedded assumptions, review design goals, and dynamically adjust AI governance practices.

To institutionalize reflexive AI governance, social work agencies can adopt community-based evaluation frameworks that combine fairness metrics with qualitative feedback from social workers and clients. Evaluation results should be made public through transparent reports, reinforcing trust and accountability (Laufer et al., 2022). As a result, participatory governance can help transform ethical pursuits into measurable, sustained practice, ensuring that AI applications in social work embody the field's enduring commitments to human dignity, justice, and cultural humility.

7 The Social Worker's Role in AI Governance

As AI becomes increasingly embedded in social service systems, social workers are called to take on vital roles in guiding and governing these technologies. This involves not only using AI tools in practice but also ensuring they align with the profession's ethical standards and social justice commitments. Drawing from core social work competencies, this section discusses the social worker's role in AI governance in three key domains: (1) ethical and professional responsibility, (2) participation and evaluation in practice, and (3) social justice and policy engagement.

7.1 *Ethical and Value-Based Leadership in AI Integration*

Social workers have a professional duty to uphold ethical standards when integrating AI into practice. This begins with recognizing that the ethical imperative is not to avoid AI, but to engage with it responsibly (Flaherty & Krishnan, 2025). Rather than passively reacting to new technologies, practitioners are urged to actively shape AI development in line with social work values (NASW, n.d.; IFSW, 2018). In practical terms, this means social workers must approach AI with the same care and ethical vigilance used in any practice context and intervention, ensuring respect for client rights, transparency, and accountability.

Adherence to professional ethics is paramount. Existing guidelines already extend ethical obligations to technology use. The NASW *Code of Ethics* (revised 2021) explicitly requires informed consent when using electronic interventions and mandates protecting client privacy and confidentiality in digital communications (Reamer, 2023). These standards also apply to AI tools. Core ethical principles like autonomy, beneficence, and justice remain guiding lights. Thus, social workers are responsible for critically assessing AI outputs and not simply accepting automated recommendations without question (Flaherty & Krishnan, 2025). They must be prepared to override or challenge an AI decision if it conflicts with the client's interests or rights, reinforcing that technology should *support rather than supplant* human judgment.

Critically, being an ethical gatekeeper also involves maintaining professional competency in technology. Social workers cannot fulfill their moral duties if they lack an understanding of how AI systems work. Recognizing this, educational bodies have begun identifying the competencies needed for ethical tech integration. A recent Council on Social Work Education (CSWE) task force emphasized foundational digital skills, including digital literacy and information literacy. It also highlighted “*technology-informed professional identity*,” integrating technology into one's practice while upholding core values (Council on Social Work Education, Commission on Educational Policy, & Task Force on Technology and Social Work Education [CSWE], 2025). In other words, social workers must continually learn about AI, stay current with emerging technologies, and critically evaluate their benefits and risks (Ahn et al., 2025). This aligns with CSWE's first competency, “ethical and professional behavior,” now interpreted in a digital context.

Not all voices in the field are unreservedly optimistic about AI in practice. Some offer cautionary perspectives on technology's impact on social work ethics. Garrett (2025), for instance, warns that an over-reliance on AI “assistants” could lead to a “*disappearance*” of social work ethics, if practitioners become complacent and trust opaque algorithms over their own judgment (Garrett, 2025). This critique underscores that social workers must remain grounded in the profession's humanistic, empathic, and reflective value base, even as they experiment with tools such as chatbots and decision aids. The “art of social work,” empathy, contextual understanding, and relational skill, cannot be coded into an algorithm (Nugent, n.d.). Social workers must therefore approach AI with a balanced perspective: Embracing

its potential benefits while fiercely protecting the core ethical principles and person-centered focus that define effective practice. By doing so, they serve as a check against both technological utopianism and the risks of ethical complacency in a data-driven era.

7.2 Participatory Design and Co-leadership in AI Systems

Beyond upholding ethical standards, social workers play a pivotal role in the participatory design and evaluation of AI interventions. Frontline practitioners possess on-the-ground insights into client needs, community contexts, and systemic barriers, often missing in tech-centric development. When included as co-designers or consultants, social workers help ensure that AI systems are fit for purpose, culturally sensitive, and aligned with real-world social service contexts. For example, if developers are creating an AI triage tool for mental health cases, social workers can advise on psychosocial factors and local resources the algorithm should consider. In such partnerships, social workers function as bridges between technical teams and the community, translating grassroots needs into technical specifications and, in turn, explaining algorithmic outputs in accessible, human terms to colleagues and clients.

Even when not explicitly co-designers, social workers are often the end users integrating AI into practice and thus key to oversight of implementation. In child welfare, social welfare benefits, health care, and other subfields relevant to social work, agencies are adopting machine learning systems for risk assessments or resource allocation. Social workers ensure these tools augment rather than replace professional judgment. Practically, this means treating an AI's recommendation as a hypothesis, one possibility, or one source of information, not an objective truth. For instance, if a predictive model flags a teenager as high risk for school dropout, a social worker will use that flag to inquire further, perhaps visiting the school, speaking with the teenager, family, and teachers, and reviewing the youth's situation holistically before deciding on any intervention. In doing so, the practitioner validates and tests the algorithm's output against reality, thereby conducting ongoing evaluation and improvement of the AI tool. This participatory oversight prevents blind trust in black-box predictions and maintains accountability, keeping humans at the center and in the loop for critical decisions. It also embodies reflexivity, with practitioners continuously reflecting on whether the AI is accurate, fair, and helpful in each case.

Notably, social workers' own perspectives on using AI highlight a preference for human-centered augmentation. In a qualitative study of clinical social workers experimenting with a large language model (ChatGPT), practitioners saw value in using AI to generate ideas and streamline paperwork, but they also raised serious concerns about confidentiality, loss of nuance, and risks of misinformation (Báez et al., 2025). Participants emphasized a "preference for augmentation rather than full automation" of practice tasks, stressing that no AI should replace the

therapeutic relationship or their professional judgment. The researchers called for comprehensive training and clear ethical guidelines to support responsible use of such tools (Báez et al., 2025). This frontline insight reinforces the importance of participatory governance: Social workers are willing to innovate with AI, but only in ways that bolster, not erode, key professional values of care, empathy, and client empowerment. In summary, by co-leading design, critically implementing and evaluating AI tools, and voicing practitioner experiences, social workers help steer AI development in a participatory, evidence-informed, and human-centered direction.

8 Challenges, Gaps, and Future Directions

AI's growing role in social work brings enormous promise but also complex ethical challenges. Across multiple AI frameworks, principles for "trustworthy AI," such as fairness, transparency, human-centeredness, accountability, and safety, align closely with social work's core values. Yet applying these ideals in practice is fraught with difficulties. Social workers have already voiced concerns that algorithmic tools could erode foundational ethics, threatening client confidentiality and privacy, limiting self-determination, and failing to engage individuals as "whole persons" (Garrett, 2025). The profession now faces the task of confronting these challenges head-on to ensure technology advances rather than undermines social work's commitment to dignity, justice, and service.

These challenges are compounded by the fact that current ethical standards and guidelines have not caught up with technological reality. Most social work codes of ethics predate the AI era; one recent review found that none of the nine principal social work codes explicitly addressed the use of predictive algorithms in decision-making (Reamer, 2023). Traditional codes provide a strong foundation of professional values, such as justice, dignity, and informed consent, but offer little guidance on AI-specific dilemmas, such as algorithmic transparency and accountability for automated decisions. However, professional organizations are beginning to respond. For instance, NASW updated its technology standards in 2017. It affirmed that digital practices must uphold social work ethics, and CSWE's Taskforce on Technology and Social Work Education recommended that social workers adopt digital and information literacy skills (CSWE, 2025).

Still, these early efforts have yet to fully articulate how practitioners should navigate issues such as data bias, model validation, and clients' rights to know when AI is involved in their care. There is an ethical capacity gap as well: Many social workers have not been trained in data science or AI oversight, leaving them ill-prepared to question or interpret algorithmic outputs. Bridging this gap will require both updating formal standards and building practitioners' literacy in AI ethics. Social workers must be empowered with new competencies to critically assess AI tools and advocate for their clients' interests in increasingly complex technological landscapes.

Looking ahead, a multifaceted effort is needed to strengthen ethical integrity as AI is integrated into social work. Governance and policy will play a key role. Policymakers are increasingly converging on risk-based regulatory approaches that align with social work values. In the European Union, for example, the *EU AI Act* designates certain human services algorithms as “high-risk.” It will require strict transparency, oversight, and auditing measures before they can be deployed. Uses of AI deemed fundamentally incompatible with rights are to be banned outright under this law. This precautionary stance aims to prevent harm and bias by design, rather than reacting after violations occur. By contrast, other jurisdictions, such as the United States, have so far favored softer, voluntary guidelines over binding rules. Such frameworks emphasize innovation and self-regulation, but they may lack the power to enforce accountability. In fields like social work, where lives and rights are at stake, many experts argue that purely voluntary ethics are insufficient. Ensuring AI tools are safe, fair, and transparent calls for enforceable standards and legislation. Social work organizations should engage with regulators to advocate for laws and policies that protect clients’ rights in algorithmic systems, mirroring the profession’s long-standing advocacy for social justice in the policy arena.

At the same time, ethical AI in social work cannot be achieved solely through top-down rules. Practical governance mechanisms are needed within agencies and communities to translate principles into everyday practice. This includes embedding ethics review and oversight into the lifecycle of any AI used in social services. Agencies might establish dedicated AI ethics committees or expand the mandate of existing review boards to vet new tools for bias, privacy, and alignment with social work’s mission. Before an algorithm is adopted to allocate resources or assess risks, it should undergo an algorithmic impact assessment, essentially, an ethical audit with input from social workers and, crucially, the clients affected. Monitoring and evaluation must then be continuous. AI systems should be regularly audited and updated as their real-world performance is observed. This proactive stance helps catch emerging biases or errors before they can cause harm, embodying a “not harm” approach in a dynamic sense. Alongside internal oversight, multi-stakeholder participation is key. Including frontline social workers, clients, and community representatives in governance not only grounds AI use in lived experiences, it also builds trust. When those affected have a voice in how an AI tool is designed, deployed, and evaluated, the tool is far more likely to reflect real community needs, cultural responsiveness, and ethical norms. This participatory ethos aligns with social work’s collaborative practice models and with international AI ethics guidelines that emphasize human rights, transparency, inclusivity, and human oversight (UNESCO, 2021).

Finally, strengthening ethical integrity in AI in the future will require that the social work profession fully embraces its role as an advocate and innovator in the tech arena. Rather than viewing AI as a threat, social workers can assert their expertise in human welfare and justice to guide technological development in more caring directions. Interdisciplinary collaboration is one avenue: Working alongside data scientists and software developers, social workers can help ensure that AI

systems are informed by social context and human values from the ground up. Co-designing AI tools with input from practitioners and service users can surface biases and cultural blind spots early, creating more fair and usable systems. Notably, some scholars argue that social workers' values and skills make them uniquely suited to mediate between technologists and communities, to champion justice and equity in the creation of AI policies and tools (Goldkind, 2021). This forward-looking stance means social workers should be present in legislative halls, research labs, and software design meetings alike. It also means investing in continuous learning within the profession: from ethics training on AI to new social work research on algorithmic impacts to revisions of curricula that prepare future social workers for a data-driven world. The mission of social work has always been to empower individuals, improve well-being, and challenge injustice, and that mission must extend into the realm of AI. By actively engaging in AI governance and development, the social work profession can help ensure these technologies are used in ways that respect human dignity and advance social good.

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